

Credit Protection Guide

Your credit information is an important part of your identity. If someone steals it, they can open up loans or other accounts in your name.

What Is a Credit Report?

A credit report is a statement that has information about your credit activity and current credit situation. Credit reports often contain your credit accounts, including the account balance and payment history. They also document the date the account was opened and closed as well as the credit limit or amount. Missed payments and loans are also included in credit reports. Credit reports also include identifying information such as your name, current and previous addresses, date of birth, and a partial Social Security number, so it is important to not disclose these with any scammers. Credit reports are very beneficial to protect your credit information and monitor your credit.

What Is a Fraud Alert?

A fraud alert is a free notification placed on your credit report that warns lenders that you may be a victim of identity theft. These notifications instruct the creditor to take steps to verify your identity or contact you directly before going forth with any request. A standard fraud alert remains in place for one year, but you can also add a seven-year fraud alert by submitting required documentation.

You can add a fraud alert to your credit report by calling **one** of the following agencies. The phone numbers below are specifically for placing fraud alerts:

- Equifax (888-766-0008)
- Experian (888-397-3742)
- TransUnion (800-680-7289)

What Is a Credit Freeze?

In a credit freeze, nobody, including yourself, can open a new credit account in your name. Credit freezes do not affect your credit score. This is

a free service, and it can be done regardless if your information has been stolen.

To place a credit freeze, you must call **all three** of the agencies above. This is different from the fraud alerts where you only need to call one of them.

Credit freezes last until you lift them, which is also done by calling all three of those credit bureaus. People usually lift credit freezes to apply for new credit or loans.

Remember, checking your credit regularly is one of the best ways to detect identity theft early. If you notice unfamiliar accounts or suspicious activity, take action promptly to help protect your finances.

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